



FULL-BLEED HERO PHOTOGRAPH
RECOMMENDED: THE SQUARE / MANAWATŪ RIVER

— YOUR JOURNEY BEGINS HERE

Palmerston North Relocation Guide

WRITTEN BY ETHICARE RESOURCING · TE PAPAIOEA



Kia ora, and a warm welcome to Aotearoa.

Kia ora, and a warm welcome to Palmerston North — Te Papaioea, the heart of the Manawatū.

Compact, affordable and friendly, 'Palmy' is a university city built around its leafy central Square. It is a place where your money goes further, the commute is short, and a strong student and research community keeps the city young.

This guide covers housing, transport, healthcare, finances and where to explore on your days off.



Lifestyle / welcome photograph

RECOMMENDED: PALMERSTON NORTH WATERFRONT OR FAMILY

Nau mai, haere mai ki Aotearoa! (Welcome to New Zealand!)

Ngā mihi nui,
The Ethicare Team

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QUICK FACTS

LOCATION

Lower central North Island

CLIMATE

Temperate, breezy

DRIVE TO WELLINGTON

~2 hours

MAIN CITY

Palmerston North (~90,000)

MAIN HOSPITAL

Palmerston North Hospital

NEARBY

Manawatū Gorge, Ruahine Ranges

Small city, big convenience

Palmerston North sits on the Manawatū plains, a flat and walkable city centred on its open green Square. Home to Massey University and a cluster of research institutes, it punches above its weight for a city its size.

90K

CITY RESIDENTS

2_{HR}

DRIVE TO WELLINGTON

1

OF NZ'S LARGEST UNIVERSITIES –
MASSEY

Why many professionals enjoy Palmerston North

- Among the most affordable cities in NZ
- Flat, compact and easy to get around
- A young, lively university and research community
- Central – well connected to Wellington and beyond

A university city at heart

Palmerston North's character is shaped by Massey University and a strong research sector — giving the city a youthful, knowledge-driven energy unusual for its size.

The central Square is the city's green heart, surrounded by cafés, galleries and the Te Manawa museum.

Rangitāne is the tangata whenua of the Manawatū, and the city has a growing multicultural community drawn by study and work.



Cultural moment

RECOMMENDED: PALMERSTON NORTH LANDMARK

“

Everything in Palmy is ten minutes away — and that quiet convenience is exactly why people stay.

ON LIFE IN PALMERSTON NORTH

Getting around

Here is how people get around Palmerston North day to day – and what to know about driving in New Zealand.

DRIVING

Flat and compact – short commutes and easy parking; State Highway 3 links the region.

BUSES

The city's bus network is straightforward and inexpensive.

AIR

Palmerston North Airport offers frequent flights to Auckland, Wellington and Christchurch.

RAIL

On the main trunk line, with the Capital Connection train to Wellington.

On the road

- New Zealanders drive on the left
- You can usually drive on a valid overseas licence for up to 12 months before converting to a NZ one
- A local transport card makes buses and trains easy
- Keep your overseas licence and any translation handy when you first arrive

A year in the local climate

Palmerston North has a temperate climate — warm summers, cool winters and the breezes that come with the Manawatū plains. Rainfall is spread through the year.

Summer

DEC – FEB

20–24°

AVG DAYTIME

Autumn

MAR – MAY

15–20°

AVG DAYTIME

Winter

JUN – AUG

9–13°

AVG DAYTIME

Spring

SEP – NOV

14–18°

AVG DAYTIME



Seasonal / scenic photograph

RECOMMENDED: MANAWATŪ GORGE / VICTORIA ESPLANADE

The plains can be breezy, but the climate is mild and gardens thrive. Bring layers and a windproof jacket for cooler, blustery days.

Healthcare in the Manawatū

Health New Zealand | Te Whatu Ora delivers care across the region from Palmerston North Hospital, the main centre for the lower central North Island.

Palmerston North Hospital

The region's main public hospital – acute, surgical, medical, maternity and emergency services, and a regional referral centre for the central North Island.

Horowhenua & Dannevirke

Smaller hospitals and health centres serve surrounding districts with local care.

Teaching & research

Strong links to Massey University and regional training make it a solid base for clinical careers.

Private & ACC

Private surgical options operate in the city; ACC provides no-fault accident cover for everyone.

Public & private

- Public healthcare is funded through general taxation
- ACC provides no-fault accident cover for everyone
- Private hospitals offer elective procedures and shorter waits
- Many residents hold private health insurance alongside the public system

GPs, pharmacies & urgent care

Registering with a GP and dentist

After you settle in, enrol with a local GP (General Practitioner). Enrolment means subsidised visits — typically around NZ\$50–\$70 when enrolled, more if you are a casual patient. Many practices allow online enrolment once you have an address. Dental care is private; expect roughly NZ\$90–\$150 for a check-up.

Pharmacies

Pharmacies are found throughout the region. Prescriptions are partly subsidised once you are enrolled with a GP — commonly a small standard charge per item.

Emergency & after-hours

- **Emergency Departments** — for urgent or critical care; in an emergency, dial 111
- **Urgent care clinics** — accident & medical clinics offer extended-hours care
- **Healthline 0800 611 116** — free 24/7 advice from registered nurses

Setting up your finances

Getting your finances in order early makes day-to-day life much easier. Most of this can be started before you arrive.

Opening a bank account

The major banks are ANZ, ASB, BNZ, Kiwibank and Westpac. You will usually need your passport, work or resident visa, and proof of a NZ address. Many banks let you start online before arrival, then activate in person. Ask for online banking and a debit card at the same time.

Tax (IRD number)

Every worker needs an IRD number from Inland Revenue. Apply online once you have a NZ address and bank account; processing usually takes around 7–10 working days. Give the number to your payroll team as soon as it arrives so the correct tax is applied. Wages are commonly paid fortnightly.

● Tip

Start your bank account application before you fly — having an account number ready makes your IRD application and payroll setup much smoother.

KiwiSaver & sending money home

KiwiSaver is a government-supported retirement savings scheme. On a work visa you can usually opt in or out. Contributions are a percentage of your pay (commonly 3%, 4%, 6%, 8% or 10%), with employers contributing at least 3%. You can withdraw your funds if you permanently leave New Zealand.

Sending money overseas: banks can transfer internationally, but specialist services such as Wise or OFX are often cheaper and faster. Always compare the exchange rate and the fees before moving larger amounts.

SET UP	WHY IT MATTERS	WHEN
Bank account	Receive salary, pay bills locally	Before / on arrival
IRD number	Be taxed correctly	First weeks
KiwiSaver	Retirement savings + employer top-up	When you start work
ACC	No-fault accident cover	Automatic

What life costs in Palmerston North

Palmerston North is one of New Zealand's most affordable cities – housing sits well below the big centres, stretching your salary further.

\$480/wk

3-BED HOUSE (APPROX. MEDIAN)

\$2.80/L

APPROX. PETROL PRICE

Left

SIDE OF THE ROAD

EVERYDAY ITEM	APPROX. PRICE (NZ\$)
1 litre of milk	\$2.50 – \$3.50
Loaf of bread	\$2.50 – \$4.00
Dozen eggs	\$7 – \$10
Flat white coffee	\$5.50 – \$6.50
Mid-range meal for one	\$25 – \$40
Monthly gym membership	\$60 – \$100
Home broadband	\$75 – \$100 / month

Prices are indicative and change over time – use the calculators at the back of this guide for a personalised estimate.

An example monthly budget

A rough single-person monthly budget for a Palmerston North renter. Yours will vary with lifestyle, household size and suburb.

CATEGORY	APPROX. MONTHLY (NZ\$)
Rent (room / small 1-bed)	\$1,100 – \$1,800
Power & water	\$150 – \$230
Internet	\$75 – \$100
Public transport / fuel	\$150 – \$260
Groceries	\$430 – \$620
Mobile phone	\$30 – \$50
Entertainment	\$150 – \$300
Estimated total	\$2,200 – \$3,400

Make it personal

- Use Numbeo to compare Palmerston North with your current city
- Map your own incomings and outgoings with the Sorted budget planner (sorted.org.nz)

A note from Sophie

A personal word from our Founder on what makes Palmerston North special – and who it tends to suit.



● SOPHIE'S INSIGHTS

Palmy is the city I recommend when someone wants their salary to go further without giving up city life. It's flat, friendly and genuinely easy – short commutes, good schools and a young, lively feel.

It doesn't shout about itself, but people who move here tend to be pleasantly surprised by how comfortable life is.

Sophie Careem · Founder & Director, Ethicare Resourcing

● From the Ethicare team

Your Ethicare contact is here to help with every step of your move to Palmerston North – from accommodation to payroll setup. Reach out any time.

Finding a place to live

Palmerston North offers excellent value – from central villas to suburban family homes – most within a short commute of the hospital and the Square.



Housing / suburb photograph

RECOMMENDED: SUBURBAN STREET OR APARTMENTS

Useful property websites

- trademe.co.nz/property – NZ's largest rental marketplace
- realestate.co.nz – nationwide rentals and homes for sale

A guide to the areas

An orientation to the main areas of Palmerston North — each with its own character, price point and who it tends to suit.

City centre & The Square

Walkable central living near cafés, shops and the green Square.

Hokowhitu

A leafy, sought-after riverside suburb popular with families and professionals.

Roslyn & Takaro

Established, affordable suburbs handy to the hospital and schools.

Aokautere & Summerhill

Newer hillside homes on the city's eastern edge with rural views.

Across the wider region

Hokowhitu

A leafy riverside suburb, popular with families and professionals.

West End & Westbrook

Character villas close to the city centre.

Aokautere & Summerhill

Newer hillside homes with rural views on the eastern edge.

Feilding & Ashhurst

Charming nearby towns for those wanting a village feel.

A tip on choosing

- Think about your commute to work and school zones if you have children
- Where you live can decide which state school your children attend – check the zone before you sign
- Many people rent for a few months first to get to know the areas

Utilities, rates & rubbish

POWER & GAS

Choose from providers like Genesis, Mercury, Meridian and Contact. Compare rates on Powerswitch (powerswitch.org.nz).

WATER & RATES

Council rates fund local services; if you rent, rates are usually included in your rent.

RUBBISH & RECYCLING

Kerbside collection is run by the local council, with separate bins for rubbish, recycling and food scraps.

INTERNET

Most homes have fibre broadband; Spark, One NZ and 2degrees are the main providers.

Set-up quick links

Compare power

powerswitch.org.nz

Post & parcels

nzpost.co.nz

Tenancy advice

tenancy.govt.nz

Where to shop

Palmerston North offers malls, town centres and weekend markets. A few of the main ones:

The Plaza (CBD)

The central-city mall on The Square.

Broadway Avenue

The main shopping and dining strip.

Terrace End & Cuba St

Suburban and specialty shopping.

Markets

The Central Energy Trust Wildbase and farmers' markets for local produce.

Supermarkets & groceries

New Zealand's supermarkets fall into a few main groups. Knowing the difference helps you balance budget and convenience.

Pak'nSave

The cheapest of the big chains — a no-frills, bulk-buy warehouse format. Best for budget shopping.

Woolworths

Mid-range and widespread, with strong online shopping and delivery (formerly Countdown).

New World

More upmarket, with a wider fresh and specialty range.

Four Square & FreshChoice

Smaller neighbourhood stores for convenience and top-ups.

Palmerston North has Pak'nSave, Woolworths and New World; nearby Feilding has New World and Four Square. Bring your own bags — single-use plastic bags are banned.

Specialty & international food

One of the joys of settling into Palmerston North is finding the flavours of home — or exploring new ones.

Halal & South Asian

Halal and Indian grocers serve the student community; many supermarket lines are halal-certified.

Asian groceries

Asian supermarkets and eateries cluster near the university and CBD.

World food

A surprisingly diverse food scene for the city's size, driven by Massey's students.

Smaller independent stores open and close over time — a quick search for "halal butcher near me" or your home cuisine will surface the current options near your suburb.

Places of worship

Palmerston North reflects New Zealand's spiritual diversity, with welcoming communities across many faiths.

Palmerston North has Christian churches of many denominations, a mosque, and Hindu and Buddhist communities.

Finding your community

- Most faith communities list service times and locations online
- Many warmly welcome newcomers and visitors
- They can be one of the quickest ways to build a support network when you arrive

Green spaces and the great outdoors

Palmerston North is a relaxed base for the outdoors – river paths, the Manawatū Gorge tracks, and the Ruahine and Tararua ranges within easy reach.



Recreation hero photograph

RECOMMENDED: MANAWATŪ GORGE / VICTORIA ESPLANADE

Don't-miss experiences

- Walk the Manawatū Gorge (Te Apiti) tracks
- Stroll the Victoria Esplanade and rose gardens
- Explore Te Manawa museum and science centre
- Hike or ride the nearby Tararua Ranges

Ten things not to miss

A starter list to get to know Palmerston North and the wider region.

- 1 Te Apiti / Manawatū Gorge**
Walk the dramatic gorge tracks and wind farm.
- 2 Victoria Esplanade**
Riverside gardens, a miniature railway and rose gardens.
- 3 Te Manawa**
Museum, art gallery and science centre in one.
- 4 New Zealand Rugby Museum**
The national shrine to the game.
- 5 The Square**
The green heart of the city.
- 6 Bledisloe & Tararua tracks**
Hiking in the nearby ranges.
- 7 Himatangi Beach**
A wide west-coast beach 30 minutes away.
- 8 Feilding**
One of NZ's most awarded towns, with a famous saleyards.
- 9 Cycleways**
Flat, scenic riding along the river and beyond.
- 10 Ashhurst Domain**
Picnics and walks at the gorge's edge.

Travel from Palmerston North

Palmerston North is a great base for exploring. Some favourite weekend escapes:

Wellington (~2 hrs)

The capital for events and city life.

Whanganui (~1 hr)

Heritage river city with galleries and character.

Taupō (~3 hrs)

The great lake and geothermal country.

Hawke's Bay (~2.5 hrs)

Wine country and Art Deco Napier.

Flying onward

- Domestic flights reach the main centres in around 1–2 hours
- Book early for the best fares on Air New Zealand and Jetstar
- Many regions are also linked by scenic road and rail journeys

Schooling & study

Palmerston North offers a full range of early childhood education, schools and tertiary study.

Early Childhood Education (ECE)

Kindergartens, daycare, Montessori, kōhanga reo and home-based care for ages 0–5. Government 20-hours funding applies for ages 3–5.

Primary & intermediate

State, state-integrated and private schools for Years 1–8.

Secondary

Years 9–13, working towards NCEA, the national qualification.

Tertiary

Universities and institutes of technology across the country.

School terms run late January to mid-December, in four terms with two-week breaks in April, July and October.

School zones come first

In New Zealand, where you live usually determines which state school your children can attend. For many families, the school decision leads the choice of where to rent or buy.

In-zone = guaranteed

Children living inside a school's enrolment zone are guaranteed a place at that school.

Out-of-zone = ballot

If you live outside the zone you can still apply, but places aren't guaranteed – popular schools run a ballot for limited spots.

Zones are street-by-street

Boundaries can run down the middle of a street, so check the exact address.

● **The order that works best**

1) Shortlist schools you like → 2) Check each school's zone map → 3) Search for rentals inside that zone → 4) Confirm the address is in-zone before you sign.

Childcare for working families

Early childhood (0–5). Daycare, kindergartens, Montessori and home-based care are widely available. The government's 20 Hours ECE funding subsidises care for ages 3–5 at participating centres.

Before & after school (OSCAR). Many schools and providers run breakfast clubs, after-school care and holiday programmes. Subsidies may be available through Work and Income for eligible families.

TYPE OF CARE	APPROX. COST (NZ\$)
Full-time daycare (under 3)	\$350 – \$450 / week before subsidies
20 Hours ECE (ages 3–5)	Up to 20 hrs/week subsidised; extra hours charged
After-school care (OSCAR)	\$5 – \$15 per afternoon, varies by provider
School holiday programme	\$40 – \$60 per day, activity-based

Costs are indicative and vary by provider and suburb. If you'll work shifts, ask providers about flexible hours.

Palmerston North for families

Beyond school and work, Palmerston North is an easy, outdoorsy place to raise a family.

FREE & OUTDOORS

The Esplanade, riverside paths and playgrounds – much of the fun is free.

RAINY-DAY OPTIONS

Te Manawa, the Rugby Museum and indoor play centres.

LIBRARIES & PLUNKET

Free libraries run children's programmes; Plunket supports young families.

GETTING AROUND

Flat, compact and cycle-friendly – among the easiest cities for families.

Settling kids in

- Children often settle fastest through school, sport and weekend activities
- Local clubs – football, netball, rugby, swimming – are inexpensive and welcoming
- They're a great way for the whole family to meet people

Pre-departure checklist

Work through these before you fly. Keep digital and printed copies of everything important.

Documents

- ☐ Passport + valid NZ visa (printed too)
- ☐ Job offer & employment contract
- ☐ Qualifications & certificates
- ☐ References & employment history

Money & travel

- ☐ Apply online for a NZ bank account
- ☐ Documents ready for your IRD number
- ☐ Confirm airline baggage allowance
- ☐ Book temporary accommodation

Your first weeks

- | | |
|---|--|
| ☐ Move into your accommodation | ☐ Open / activate your bank account |
| ☐ Apply for your IRD number | ☐ Get a NZ SIM card |
| ☐ Register with a local GP | ☐ Set up power, water and internet |
| ☐ Learn your transport routes to work | ☐ Save 111 and Healthline in your phone |
| ☐ Find your nearest pharmacy & supermarket | ☐ Explore your local neighbourhood |

● You're not alone

Your Ethicare contact is here to help with any of these steps – from accommodation to payroll setup. Reach out any time.

Key numbers & contacts

In any emergency – police, fire or ambulance – dial **111**.

Emergency & health

Emergency	111
Healthline	0800 611 116
Mental health	Call/text 1737
Police (non-urgent)	105

Everyday services

Tax (IRD)	ird.govt.nz
Immigration	immigration.govt.nz
AA roadside	0800 500 222
Local council	govt.nz/organisations

Banks

ANZ	anz.co.nz
ASB	asb.co.nz
BNZ	bnz.co.nz
Kiwibank	kiwibank.co.nz
Westpac	westpac.co.nz

Community & expat groups

One of the quickest ways to settle in is to find your people. Palmerston North has active communities for almost every interest and background.

Facebook groups

Search for groups like "Expats in Palmerston North", your home-country community, and local suburb buy/sell and parents' groups.

Meetup & interest groups

Meetup.com lists hiking, sport, hobby and newcomer groups — a relaxed way to meet people.

Sports & cultural clubs

Local football, netball, rugby and cricket clubs, plus cultural and faith communities, all welcome newcomers.

Workplace networks

Many hospitals and employers have social clubs and buddy systems for new and international staff.

Rainbow / LGBTQ+ community

- New Zealand is welcoming and progressive — marriage equality has been law since 2013
- There are strong legal protections against discrimination
- OutLine Aotearoa offers rainbow mental-health support (0800 688 5463)

Everyday Māori & Kiwi phrases

Te reo Māori is part of everyday life, and Kiwis have their own slang too.

Te reo Māori

Kia ora Hello / thanks

Nau mai, haere mai Welcome

Whānau Family

Hauora Health & wellbeing

Manaakitanga Hospitality, kindness

Mōrena Good morning

Ka kite anō See you later

Tamariki Children

Ngā mihi nui Many thanks

Aotearoa New Zealand

Kiwi slang

Sweet as Great / no worries

Keen Up for it

Dairy Corner shop

Jandals Flip-flops

Flatting Shared renting

Chur Cheers / thanks

Heaps Lots

Togs Swimwear

Shout Your turn to pay

Knackered Tired

Work out your cost of living.

Use these tools to estimate what life in Palmerston North would really cost for you and your family.

Cost-of-living calculators

Compare cities (Numbeo)	numbeo.com/cost-of-living
Budget planner (Sorted)	sorted.org.nz/tools/budget-planner
Living-costs data (Stats NZ)	stats.govt.nz
Take-home pay (IRD)	ird.govt.nz

We hope you've found this guide useful. Moving to the other side of the world is a big step, and there's a lot to take in – so please don't feel you have to have it all figured out at once.

Whatever stage you're at, we're always happy to talk anything through – the big decisions or the small worries. Just reach out to your Ethicare contact whenever you need us.

Ngā mihi nui

The Ethicare team



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